



The Lap Steel Guitar

Definition

The steel guitar differs from a regular guitar in the way that it is played. The lap steel guitar is held in your lap facing toward you. The strings are raised above the fretboard; rather than pressing them to the fretboard, a steel bar is pressed against the strings. Typically the lap steel guitar is tuned in one of several "open" [tunings](#) rather than standard guitar tuning.

Origin

Steel guitars were originally invented and popularized in Hawaii. Legend has it that **Joseph Kekuku**, a Hawaiian schoolboy, discovered the sound while walking along a railroad track strumming his guitar. He picked up a bolt lying by the track and slid the metal along the strings of his guitar. Intrigued by the sound, he taught himself to play using the back of a knife blade.

Other persons who have been credited with the invention of the steel guitar include **Gabriel Davion**, an Indian sailor, around 1885, and **James Hoa**, a Hawaiian of Portuguese ancestry.

Hawaiian groups were a big hit at the [1915 Panama-Pacific International Exposition](#) in San Francisco. From there the sound of the Hawaiian guitar spread throughout the United States. From about 1915 to 1930, a large number of Hawaiian guitar methods and songs were published by the major music publishers.

The sound of the Hawaiian guitar was picked up and incorporated into blues and country music. From there, the steel guitar slid its way into rock, pop, African and [Indian](#) music.

More information about Hawaiian steel guitar may be found on the [Hawaiian Steel Guitar Association web site](#).

Performers

Performers who are well known as steel guitarists (as opposed to slide guitarists) include:

Speedy West	David Lindley	Alvino Rey	Dan Dugmore
Roy Smeck	Bob Brozman	Eddie Alkire	Herb Remington
Jerry Byrd	Junior Brown	Noel Boggs	Johnny Farina
Leon McAuliffe	Joe Goldmark	Vance Terry	Joaquin Murphey
Sol Hoopii	Pete Drake	Bob Dunn	Don Helms
Freddie Roulette	Ben Harper	John Ely	"Little" Roy Wiggins
Sonny Rhodes	B.J. Cole	Buddy Emmons	Ken Emerson

Weissenborn acoustic guitars

The forefather of the National, Dobro® and pedal steel guitars was conceived and built by Hermann Weissenborn in the early 1920's.

Hermann C. Weissenborn, a German piano and violin maker, emigrated to New York around 1902. In 1910 he moved to Los Angeles where he mainly did repair work on instruments until the end of the decade. With the Hawaiian music boom of the early 20's, Weissenborn started making ukeleles, flat-tops and eventually Hawaiian steel guitars. [Chris J. Knutsen](#) made similar guitars in the Seattle area at the same time. Both makers' guitars are sought after and imitated by contemporary builders, although they are usually referred to generically as **Weissenborn** guitars.

With their raised string action, frets flush with the fingerboard, square hollow necks and featherweight koa wood construction, the Weissenborns offered both greater volume and sustain than conventional Spanish

neck guitars for Hawaiian lap steel playing. Due to their sweet timbre, expressive tone and eye catching design these guitars were an instant hit and stayed in demand until the advent of resonator guitars.

These guitars have experienced a revival due to their use by such artists as [David Lindley](#) and [Ben Harper](#) among others.

[Christiaan Oyens](#) has an excellent site devoted to these instruments. There's also a good [Weissenborn site in Spain](#).

Dobro® and resonator guitars

Many country and bluegrass players use the [Dobro®](#) (or a resonator guitar), a steel guitar which uses an internal resonator to make it louder. "Dobro®" is a registered trademark of the Original Musical Instrument Company. Other resonator-equipped guitars are made by [many different companies](#). You will see these referred to as "resophonic" or "ampliphonic" guitars. According to Bangs Tapscott, other resophonic guitars should be referred to as a **TIFKAD** (The Instrument Formerly Known As Dobro). Well known modern Dobro® players include:

[Jerry Douglas](#)
[Oswald Kirby](#)
[Josh Graves](#)
[Stacy Phillips](#)
[Sally Van Meter](#)

[Mike Auldridge](#)
[Doug Cox](#)
[Rob Ickes](#)
[Tab Tabscott](#)
[Carl Weingarten](#)

[Tut Taylor](#)
[Kelly Joe Phelps](#)
[Phil Leadbetter](#)
[John Fogerty](#)

Pedal Steel Guitar

The steel guitar eventually mutated as players sought to expand its usage. Additional strings were added, then additional necks. As the guitars got heavier, they were placed on legs, changing from lap steels to table steels. Finally pedals and knee levers were attached to the strings, allowing the player to change tunings as the guitar is played.

There are many web sites devoted to the [pedal steel guitar](#) if you want more information. [Carter Steel Guitars](#) has a very good site with lots of information. They're the hosts of the [Steel Guitar Information](#) website. [Bobby Lee Quasar](#) had the first pedal steel guitar site on the internet and runs a most excellent [Steel Guitar Forum](#) with many good discussions. Another good site is run by [Dave Van Allen](#) (check out his steel guitar timeline!). [Joe Wright](#) has a great web site with lots of information on learning to play pedal steel guitar.

All these sites have good information for the pedal steel guitar enthusiast- I recommend you check them all out. There will be many links on these sites which will take you to further sites.

Slide Guitar

The slide guitar is typically a standard guitar, held the usual way, and fretted with a piece of metal or glass, typically a tube worn on one finger. The sound of the slide guitar can be quite similar to the steel guitar. Famous slide guitarists include (but are not limited to):

[Blind Willie Johnson](#)
[Elmore James](#)
[Robert Johnson](#)
[Muddy Waters](#)
[Duane Allman](#)

[Ry Cooder](#)
[Bonnie Raitt](#)
[Johnny Winter](#)
[Lowell George](#)
[Chris Whitley](#)

[Mike Cooper](#)
[Sonny Landreth](#)
[Roy Rogers](#)
[Tony Furtado](#)
[Michael Messer](#)

Other Pages in this site

Here's a page of [steel guitar tablature](#) with contributions from several people.

I've put together [a list of resources for the steel guitarist](#), such as guitar builders, stores that specialize in steel guitars, recommended tutorials, videos, etc. Check out the index at the side of this page for a breakdown by category.

There are a lot of [steel guitar CDs](#) out there. Here are some recommendations by me and other steel players.

There are many ways to tune the lap steel guitar. I have [a list of some of the most common tunings](#).

Click here to see my discussion about various [lap steel manufacturers](#), now including pictures of old instruments. ([Clay Harrel's web site](#) has **lots** more information on acoustic steel guitar manufacturers of the past.)

Believe it or not, there are a number of [Indian steel guitar](#) players. It's country music from another country! (Check out in particular [Debashish Bhattacharya](#))

So what have I done? Here's my [musical resume](#).

Of course, no web site would be complete without a [page of links](#). Mine are mostly guitar related.

Other links you should investigate

John Tipka has an excellent site devoted to [Hawaiian Steel Guitar](#), with information on Fender Stringmasters, building your own steel guitar, and some songs to learn.

Howard Parker has a [site for Dobro® and other resophonic guitarists](#). Among other things, it has some good pictures of Mike Auldridge and Jerry Douglas. Howard also hosts the resophonic discussion list **Resoguit**. It's a great resource for those of us who play acoustic lap steel guitars. Visit his web site to subscribe.

Here is a discussion of [Hawaiian steel guitar](#) from [Lark In The Morning Music](#) in Mendocino, California.

A Usenet newsgroup devoted to the steel guitar has been created. It's called [alt.guitar.lap-pedal](#). Clicking on the name may take you to it, if your service provider and internet browser allow such things. You'll find much better information on the [Steel Guitar Forum](#), though.

If you really want to find out more about **steel**, click [here](#).

Common Tunings For Lap Steel Guitar

The image to the right is by Robert Morrow, and is reproduced here by permission. The guitarist is [Chris Darrow](#) and this is the cover from his Pacific Arts release "Fretless".

The cool whiny sound that the steel bar makes when slid against a guitar string has one big limitation. You can't make fancy chords (minor, seventh, etc.) without tuning your guitar to a different tuning than the standard guitar tuning. (Actually, I recommend trying to play lap steel using regular guitar tuning once in a while. It may give you a different sound than you would otherwise get!)

All tunings are shown from the bass (lowest) string, which I'll call the sixth string, to the treble (highest) string, which I'll call the first string. Using this system, **standard guitar tuning** would be represented as:

1. E
2. B
3. G
4. D
5. A
6. E

Additional strings on your guitar means you can expand the tuning possibilities. Thanks to **Herb Steiner** and **Bob Quasar**, I've added some tunings for [eight-string guitar](#) at the bottom of the page.

Certain tunings require that you use a different set of strings than a normal electric or acoustic guitar would use. **Bob Quasar** has a [string gauge chart](#) on his pedal steel web page. **Just Strings** has a wide variety of lap steel strings available. You'll get a good overview of what is commercially available by visiting this site. **GHS Strings** has a list of string sets they sell for acoustic slide guitar and electric Hawaiian and pedal steel guitar. **Ernie Ball**'s web site has a list of their [pedal steel guitar string sets](#), both in E9th and C6th ten-string sets. Remove two (or four) strings and you have your lap steel string gauges!

The most common tuning for acoustic steel guitar (Dobro) is **open G**:

1. D
2. B
3. G
4. D
5. B
6. G

One advantage to this tuning is that you have three sets of strings one octave apart for each note in a major chord. It's easy to play the same thing an octave higher or lower by just moving down (or up) three strings. It's also great for quick hammer-on type playing.

Some people use this tuning tuned up a whole step to **open A**:

1. E
2. C#
3. A
4. E
5. C#
6. A

There is also a tuning called **low bass A** or **Hawaiian A**:

1. E
2. C#
3. A
4. E
5. A
6. E

This is the original tuning used in many early Hawaiian guitar instruction books. If you find a very old book without any indication of which tuning is being used, it's probably this tuning. This tuning is also frequently seen tuned one whole note lower, as **low bass G**:

1. D
2. B
3. G
4. D
5. G
6. D

These tunings allow a nice fingerpicking rhythm to be set up, alternating the root and fifth of the chord using the bottom three strings. It's a nice tuning to use if you play solo. The low bass G tuning is used by [Bob Brozman](#) on his National steel guitars.

On electric lap steel guitar, I started out by using **open E**:

1. E
2. B
3. G#
4. E
5. B
6. E

although some people prefer the same tuning in **open D**:

1. D
2. A
3. F#
4. D
5. A
6. D

The advantage for me in using this tuning is that the tonic (the note representing the base to which all other notes relate) is represented three times, and the third (which indicated whether the chord is major or minor) is only present once. By leaving this note in or out of your playing, you can "fake" playing minor chords. This type of tuning also lets me play sixths on the top and third string up and down the neck for a Hank Williams/pedal steel effect. This tuning is also great for power chords played through a highly overdriven amp.

The **C6/Am7 Tuning** has been mentioned several times by different people. It's tuned as follows:

1. E
2. C
3. A
4. G
5. E
6. C

The advantage to this tuning is you have almost every type of chord interval under the bar without having to slant the bar. C E G is an C major chord, A C E G is an A minor 7th chord, C E G A is a C sixth chord, etc. You can play sixths up and down the neck without slanting the bar as much as you would in the open E tuning due to the fact that you have two sets of strings situated a sixth apart (the second and fifth strings are a major sixth, the first and fourth strings are a minor fifth).

The disadvantage is that everything you play sounds Hawaiian until you get your act together (or until you join a Hawaiian band). Once you learn how to play the right combination of strings (and more importantly, how to stay away from certain strings), you can play many different styles. Because the bottom strings are tuned much higher than normal, many people use a combination of fifth and/or fourth strings (in other words, lighter gauge strings) in the bottom three strings. This is the tuning that **DeWitt "Scotty" Scott** uses in his [Basic C6th Nonpedal Lap Steel Method](#).

Some people play this tuning with the bottom string tuned to C# rather than C. This makes it a **A7 tuning** and gives you additional chordal possibilities. I think this tuning works better with eight strings.

Here's a list of some other common tunings. Some of these are from **Stacy Phillips'** steel guitar methods; others from playing around; others are suggested by other players.

Alternative C6 Tuning:

1. E
2. C
3. G
4. E
5. C
6. A

Another C6 Alternate Tuning:

1. E
2. C
3. A
4. G
5. C
6. G

Yet Another C6 Alternate Tuning:

1. E
2. C
3. A
4. G
5. C
6. E

The three tunings above are variations of the C6 tuning I've described previously. Each one has its strengths and weaknesses. Experiment with each to see which one fits your style best.

Here's another C6 Tuning:

1. G
2. E
3. C
4. A
5. G
6. E

Keith Cary says of this tuning: I was lucky enough to get a long lesson from Vance Terry about 15 years ago. His pedal steel was set up at a club somewhere so I brought one of my spare 6-strings for him to play on. (I only had 6-strings at the time) It was tuned E-G-A-C-E-G. He said that if he only had six strings that's the way he's tune it. He was amazing with those six strings, making fat jazz chords look so effortless. It has that nice 1-3-5 Dobro thing happening on top, giving just a little more space if you want to avoid the 6th. It's always felt too strange to me to not have the root or fifth as the top string.

G6 Tuning:

1. D
2. B
3. G
4. E
5. B
6. G

This tuning is great for playing the classic ballad "Sleepwalk" by Santo and Johnny. Another variation of this tuning leaves the bottom three strings in the open G tuning described above, then moves the sixth note to the third string as follows:

1. B
2. G
3. E
4. D
5. B
6. G

G9 Tuning:

1. D
2. A
3. G
4. D
5. B
6. G

C13 Tuning:

1. E
2. C
3. G
4. Bb
5. D
6. A

C# Minor Tuning:

1. E
2. C#
3. G#
4. E
5. C#
6. G#

F#9 Tuning:

1. E
2. C#
3. G#
4. E
5. A#
6. F#

B11 Tuning:

1. E
2. C#
3. A
4. F#
5. D#
6. B

Em or G6 tuning:

1. E
2. B
3. G
4. D

5. B
6. E

Lance Ashdown writes about this tuning:

This tuning has the advantage that it is only different from the standard guitar tuning on one string (hey, it makes it easier for those learning steel as a second language), yet gives easy one-fret bar positionings of all major and minor chords in the standard folk and country keys.

1. D
2. B
3. G
4. D
5. B
6. E

This tuning was suggested by Pieter Verkuylen (verkuyle@xs4all.nl), who says about it:

I play an old Irish reel called 'Princess Royal' in this tuning and a chord/melody arrangement of 'Round Midnight', a slow, melancholic jazz classic. I also use this tuning for one or two songs in the band. It works well in E and Emin of course, but also in songs in Amin. The -min7 sound gives extra 'flavour' that fits well in rock and jazz tunes/songs and makes accompanying swing/bebop tunes with all those II V I- chord progressions a lot easier. Retuning is quickly done: I hate to spend much time tuning on stage.

E13 Tuning:

1. E
2. C#
3. G#
4. E
5. D
6. B

Cmaj9 Tuning:

1. D
2. B
3. G
4. E
5. C
6. G

The above tuning gives you three chords - C major (G C E G), E minor 7 (E G B D) and G major (G G B D).

Hide Hanenburg's open Gsus2 Tuning:

1. D
2. A
3. G
4. D
5. G
6. C

Note that in this tuning, the sixth string is tuned higher than the fifth string, one whole note below the fourth string.

William Leavitt's new tuning from Steel Guitar World:

1. D
2. C
3. Bb
4. G
5. E
6. C#

This tuning gives you a C# diminished chord, a G minor chord, and a C major chord, among others. It's a very interesting tuning for jazzier tunes. More information on this tuning, including tab for a series of jazz standards, can be obtained from **Mike Ihde** (mihde@berklee.edu). **Joe Wright** lists all the [modal patterns for this tuning \(in the key of C\)](#) on his excellent [web site](#).

David Hamburger's G11 tuning from the July 1996 **Guitar Player** magazine:

1. C
2. A
3. F
4. D
5. B
6. A

David Torn's lap steel tuning from September 1996 **Guitar Player** magazine:

1. D
2. C#
3. B
4. F#
5. B
6. E

Hide Hanenburg says of this tuning, "I tried it a few nights ago and I thought it sounded ambient, ethereal, "pretty" -- and kinda weird. I thought it was cool, so I'm keeping one of my lap steels in this tuning for now."

[Bob Brozman](#) wrote me recently with some additional modal tunings that look like a lot of fun. If you are playing solo lap steel, you should definitely experiment with these tunings. Check out Bob's recent article in [Guitar Player](#) magazine.

1. C
2. C
3. G
4. C
5. G
6. C

The lack of a third note in the above tuning makes it easy to imply either a major or minor chord.

1. D
2. C
3. G
4. C
5. G
6. C

Bob says the above tuning gives a great modal sound.

1. Eb
2. C
3. G
4. C
5. G
6. C

1. E
2. C
3. G
4. C
5. G
6. C

Note that the four tunings above are exactly the same except for the highest string. As you change the pitch of the highest string, the entire feel of the tuning changes. Look at the same type of changes represented in the G tunings below.

1. D
2. Bb
3. G
4. D
5. G
6. D

1. D
2. B
3. F#
4. D
5. G
6. D

1. D
2. C
3. G
4. D
5. G
6. D

The following two tunings are centered around a D tonality. Compare them to the open D tuning mentioned previously.

1. D
2. A
3. F
4. D
5. A
6. D

1. D
2. A
3. G
4. D
5. A
6. D

This tuning is the one used by Ben Harper on his Weissenborn-style guitars. The lack of a third means the major/minor problem previously discussed is not present in this tuning.

1. D
2. A
3. D
4. D
5. A
6. D

Bill Reid writes, "Makuakane, Billy Reid Sr. played a D9th and I have followed suit:

1. E
2. C
3. A
4. F#
5. D
6. A

"You have your major DF#A with an optional lower bass A also the seventh with the C. The top three strings give you the minor chord like the C6th The F#AC give you the diminished chords. When slanted, the top three strings give you the 6th chords and slanted 5,4,3 give you the related major chords. In some respects it's like the B11th . He played C#mi for many years and E7th and AMaj .The D9th is a fast melodic tuning and and great for popular as well as Hawaiian."

Eight String Tunings

Additional strings on your guitar means even greater tuning potential. With the additional strings, you can minimize the number of slants you have to play to get your guitar to match the song's harmonies. Here are some suggested tunings for eight-string steel guitars.

A6 Tuning:

1. E
2. C#
3. A
4. F#
5. E
6. C#
7. A
8. F#

This is a very popular tuning, used by Herb Remington among others. I'm using this currently on my Fender Deluxe 8 and find it very useful; it's similar to the open A tuning discussed above, but with the added 6th note (F#) allowing use of minor chords and sixth intervals.

C6/Am7 Tuning:

1. G
2. E
3. C
4. A
5. G
6. E
7. C
8. A

This is an extension of the C6/Am7 tuning listed above in the six string tunings. The addition of an A to the bass and a G to the treble seems to center this tuning around A rather than around C, as on the six string version.

E13 Tuning: (as used by [Leon McAuliffe](#))

1. E
2. C#
3. B
4. G#
5. F#
6. D
7. G#
8. E

C6/FMaj9 Tuning:

1. E
2. C
3. A
4. F
5. E
6. C
7. A
8. F

C13 Tuning: (as used by [Junior Brown](#))

1. G
2. E
3. C
4. A
5. G
6. E
7. C
8. Bb

C Diatonic Tuning (as used by [Jerry Byrd](#)):

1. C
2. B
3. A
4. G
5. F
6. E
7. D
8. C

Expanded E7 Tuning:

1. E
2. B
3. G#
4. E
5. D
6. B
7. G#
8. E

Bob Lee's New Hawaiian Tuning:

1. E
2. D
3. C#
4. A
5. F#
6. D
7. B
8. A

MDFried's E6 tuning:

1. E
2. C#
3. B
4. G#
5. E
6. C#
7. B
8. E

Bob Lee's E6 tuning:

1. G#
2. E
3. C#
4. B
5. G#

6. E
7. D
8. B

Bob says, "I'm using this tuning currently on my eight-string Fender Deluxe. This tuning allows me to play sixths up and down a scale with practically no slanting."

Andrew Waegel's A major/minor 7th tuning:

1. G
2. E
3. C
4. A
5. G
6. E
7. C#
8. A

Andrew says, "It's basically the Jerry Byrd C6/A7 tuning with an added high G on the top string to make more third intervals accessible without too much neck motion. It also gives more options for those high sweet tones that I hear so much of in the older country music that I like to play."

Bobby Black's C6/A7 tuning:

1. E
2. C
3. A
4. G
5. E
6. C#
7. A
8. B

According to Cartwright Thompson (Bigbudhick@aol.com), "I got this one from Bobby Black, he said he got it from [Joquin Murphey](#). The cool thing here is that the bottom B string is tuned an octave higher (1/2 step below the second string). So you have the Jerry Byrd C6/A7 on the top 7, but you can grab the bottom string for a very pretty major 7th, and you get a nice "strummable" A9th chord on the bottom 5 strings."

Bob Quasar's D13 tuning:

1. E
2. F#
3. D
4. B
5. A
6. F#
7. D
8. C

The top E is tuned between the third string (D) and the second string (F#). This allows a four-note pattern to be played by picking alternately on the C# D E F# strings. I can see how this would be very useful in certain situations.

Michael McClellan's G13 tuning:

1. G
2. E
3. C
4. A
5. F
6. D
7. B
8. G

Michael McClellan writes:

John Coltrane got me into it! This does wild things to "Sand" (the Hawaiian instrumental), "Misty" (Errol Gardner's classic), some polkas, and many country beer-drinkers. I pull a string behind the steel with my left hand ring finger, and can get some of the pedal-steel effects while still keeping the Dobro® purity. Using this trick, I can make a weird part of the 13th into a normal major chord. The G13 gives me inversions of a 7th, a 9th, a 6th, a Major 7th, an 11th, and a minor. It gives a real 13th, from root to treble, which the other 13ths don't. When you end a song on this chord, folk sit up and listen!

Pete Grant's D tuning:

1. F#
2. E
3. D
4. A
5. F#
6. D
7. A
8. D

This tuning has the second and third notes of the D scale on the top two strings. Pete wrote this about it on the [Steel Guitar Forum](#):

When I had National Reso-Phonic build me an 8-string Model D, it was for the express purpose of allowing me to play Irish traditional music in a more competent manner. After trying all kinds of tunings, I came up with D tuning with a 2 and a 3 of the scale on top. It turned out to be just what I'd been looking for.

A Good Question About Tuning

Zak Watson (c642063@showme.missouri.edu) wrote me, asking the following:

In the numerous tunings you cite on your page, I assume that when the sixth string is tuned to C, that is down from what would be standard on a normal (ie non steel) guitar. Am I correct? I also am assuming (since you made reference to alternate stringings) that all the other strings are, as a rule tuned up from what would be standard. I guess what I'm trying to get at is: Is there a rule of thumb for whether to tune my strings up or down to achieve all of the different alternate tunings?

It really depends on the tuning whether you tune the string up or down. For example, if standard guitar tuning from low to high string is **E A D G B E**, to tune to open E tuning, you'd tune the A string up to B, the D string up to E, and the G string up to G#.

For C6 tuning the way I've been playing it, you would tune the E string up to C, the A string up to E, the D string up to G, the G string up to A, the B string up to C, and leave the high E string alone.

If you're using regular gauge guitar strings, you risk snapping your lower strings. In the C6 tuning mentioned above, I have used **Ernie Ball Power Slinky** strings (.11 top string to .48 bottom), but usually use a custom set of single strings based on [Bob Quasar's string gauge chart](#).

If you use a regular set of guitar strings and want to play in a differently voiced C6 tuning, I would leave the low E string as it is, tune the A down to G, tune the D down to C, tune the G up to A, tune the B up to C, and leave the high E string as it is.

I hope this makes sense. Buy some inexpensive strings (I like the Ernie Ball strings for this purpose) and have at it. The good thing about experimenting with tunings on a lap steel is you cannot make the neck go out of adjustment by tuning the strings too high. (I won't guarantee the same thing with acoustic steel guitars!) I've even played in open G, but instead of **G B D G B D**, I've tuned to **G D G B D G** (like open E tuning, but three steps higher).

Thanks to

- *Jeff Mead for suggesting this page in the first place.*
- *Herb Steiner for the eight-string tunings.*

- *Hidde Hanenberg for the interesting tunings.*
- *(L5C@aol.com) for telling me about the Leavitt tuning.*
- *Andrew Waegel for another A tuning.*
- *Cartwright Thompson for Bobby Black's tuning.*
- *[Bob Brozman](#) (bobbrozman@worldnet.att.net) for sharing his knowledge.*
- *Michael McClellan for the G13 tuning.*
- *Bob Quasar for running the [steel guitar forum](#) and providing me with interesting, usable tunings.*
- *Robert Morrow for the use of the image at the top of the page*

Songs for Steel Guitar in Tablature Format

I'm no longer taking requests for tablature, as this page has grown larger than my ability to maintain it. I highly recommend [TablEdit](#), a program for Windows and Macintosh computers, as a good program to use for creating tablature. The author has gone out of his way to work with steel guitarists.

[Roy Thompson](#) has an excellent collection of non-pedal tablature (with accompanying sound files) on his [web site](#).

Here's an excellent source for some [tablature for various slide guitar artists](#), including **Ry Cooder** and **Johnny Winter** among others.

[Tab Tabscott](#) has a good collection of resophonic tablature on his web site. Another source of tablature with varying degrees of difficulty may be found on [Howard Parker's resoguit web site](#). **Folk of the Wood** has a series of pages on [How to Read & Understand Tablature for DOBRO®](#). The [Dobro® Players Anonymous](#) web site has a pretty good collection of tablature. [Jay Buckey's web site](#) has some tablature for Dobro® and other instruments in Adobe Acrobat (PDF) format. [Strum Hollow](#) has a few tunes for resophonic guitars in MIDI, Tab and TablEdit format.

If you don't know what tablature is or have other questions, look at the [OnLine Guitar Archive \(OLGA\)](#).

Open E or open D tuning (bass to treble, E B E G# B E or D A D F# A D)

- [I'll Fly Away](#), a traditional song arranged by [Pete Grant](#)
- [Blackbird](#) by Paul McCartney and John Lennon, also arranged by Pete Grant
- [Steel Guitar Rag](#) by Leon McAuliffe arranged by me
- [Ashokan Farewell](#) by Jay Unger arranged by Andy Volk

Open G tuning (bass to treble, G B D G B D)

- [Bill Cheatham](#) transcribed by Gregory Tucker-Kellogg
- [Swallow Tail Jig](#) arranged by Mark Panfil

C6/Am7 tuning (bass to treble, C E G A C E)

- [Warmth Of The Sun](#), a Beach Boys tune arranged by Andy Volk. (here's a [MIDI file](#) of the same song)
- [Back At The Chicken Shack](#), a Jimmy Smith tune arranged by Andy Volk.
- [Sleepwalk](#), my interpretation of the Santo and Johnny classic steel guitar song.
- [Steelin Home](#), an instrumental originally done by Noel Boggs and His Daysleepers, arranged by Andy Volk.
- [Aloha Oe](#), arranged by John Tipka
- [Surf Medley](#), (Walk Don't Run/Pipeline) arranged by Andy Volk.

A7/C6 tuning (bass to treble, C# E G A C E)

- [A Teardrop On A Rose](#), by Hank Williams, arranged by John Tipka

G6 tuning (bass to treble, G B E G B D)

- [Sleepwalk](#), another version of the Santo and Johnny classic steel guitar song.

B11 tuning (bass to treble, C# D# F# A C# E)

- [Nani Waimea](#), a classic Hawaiian tune arranged by Andy Volk.

C tuning (bass to treble, C G C E G C)

- [How Can You Keep Moving \(Unless You Migrate Too\)](#), a tune originally written by Agnes Cunningham, covered by Ry Cooder. This version transcribed by Tim Tweedale.

*Thanks to **Pete Grant, Andy Volk, Tim Tweedale, Mark Panfil, John Tipka, Keith Saturn, and Gregory Tucker-Kellogg** for taking the time to contribute to this page.*

The Blues Scale in C6th Tuning for Lap Steel

by Andy Volk

There are many styles of music that feature some degree of improvisation, such as jazz, blues, Hawaiian, country, and even certain classical music styles. In fact, in [Handel](#)'s time, any self respecting harpsichord player in a duo or trio would be expected to improvise his or her accompaniment from a [sketch of the bass line](#) - much like reading from a "fake book".

In the music we play today, improvisation can run the gamut from slightly altering a melody to spontaneously composing a new melody over the chord changes of a tune. Improvisers notebook will look at musical tools and ideas useful for people who want to learn to improvise on the steel guitar.

The blues forms the backbone for much of 20th century American popular music. As one listen to [Sol Hoopii](#) or Benny Nawahi will confirm, even Hawaiian music wasn't untouched by the blues.

So ... when [B.B. King](#) rears back and takes a searing blues solo is he so overcome with emotion that his fingers just find the right notes? Nah, he knows several scale positions to use that will yield notes that sound good in a blues tune. (Not to say that emotion isn't a part of playing the blues - it's the hardest part!)

One of the most infallible ways for a beginning improviser to create pleasing improvisations is to use the "blues scale". That's because all of the notes in the scale will sound good with almost any basic blues tune, in a major or minor key. The important thing is to use the scale with the same root name as the key you're playing in. The "blues scale" let's you play one scale over the entire chord progression with virtually no chance of hitting any "clunker" notes.

"Blues scale" is really a slang name for a scale whose formal name is the Pentatonic Minor scale. All the following examples are in the key of A and can be played in C6th tuning (bottom to top string: C E G A C E) over a blues chord progression in the key of A.

Let's first look at the structure of the Pentatonic Minor scale in the key of A. *Penta* means five, but we've added the lowered 5th of the scale as a passing tone making this a six note scale. To understand the structure of the scale, we'll first play it entirely on the E string..

Scale degree:	root	b3	4th	b5th	5th	b7	root
E	5	8	10	11	12	15	17
C							
A							
G							
E							
C							

The flat 3rd, flat 5th, and flat 7th are the "blue" notes that give this scale its characteristic sound.

Here are some positions for the A Minor Pentatonic scale in C6th Tuning. They all begin on the A root note.

E					5		
C			7	9		7	
A			7			7	6 5
G		7	8				5
E	8						5
C	9						

This position allows a long, expressive slide to the 5th fret root :

E	5	3					
C		4	3	2		9	
A				3		10	
G				2		9	8 7
E							8 5
C							

Here's a two octave version for more bar movement and a more "singing" legato sound:

E							15	17
C						14	15	16
A					12	15		
G		7	8	9	12			
E	8							
C	9							

[B.B. King](#) uses a variation that starts from the 6th, adds the 9th and offers a more jazzy sound.

Scale degree:	6th	root	2nd/9th	b3	4th	5th
E						5
C			2	4		6
A		2	3			7
G	2				5	7
E	2			5	7	
C			6			

The Pentatonic Major scale is basically the same as the Pentatonic Minor except it's found 3 frets below each minor pentatonic position and doesn't contain that extra note. The major pentatonic has a bright, sweet sound to most people's ears when compared to the "harder", "darker" sound of the Pentatonic Minor. The Pentatonic Major is used a lot in country music and you can also use it to add a blusey feel to a non-blues song.

Some Pentatonic Major positions:

E			5		14	12
C		4	6		13	11
A		4				12
G	4					11
E	5					12 9

Learning to improvise is similar to learning to speak a language. Before you can speak in complete sentences, you need to learn vocabulary, grammar, sentence structure, etc., but with time and effort, you'll become more and more conversant. But don't just play these scales from root to root. Seek out the melodies within the scale. Try playing the Pentatonic Minor over the I chord and the Pentatonic Major or BB King scale over the IV chord. Experiment to find the sounds that best express your own feelings.

Like Hawaiian music, the source of the blues sound is the human voice. The best blues instrumentalists imitate vocalists. Luckily for us, the steel guitar is perhaps the most voice-like of all musical instruments. One hint: vibrato is one of the most individualistic aspects of steel playing and blues playing seems to lend itself, especially at slower tempos, to use of vibrato. (Again, listen to B.B. King!)

Sources for more information: Like any other music you want to learn, listen to the phrasing of master artists in the idiom. Here's a short list of some of my idiosyncratic, personal favorites for blues:

- [Sol Hoopii](#) (steel)
- Nat Cole Trio (piano)
- Louis Armstrong (trumpet)
- Earl Hooker (slide guitar)
- Albert Collins (guitar)
- [Freddie Roulette](#) (steel)
- Little Walter (harmonica)
- T-Bone Walker (guitar)
- James Cotton (harmonica)
- Rod Piazza & the Mighty Flyers (great harmonica & guitar playing)

[Rhino Records](#) has a 15 volume series of individual CDs or cassettes called the Blues Masters Series. The series highlights classic performances in all types of blues from the hardcore Chicago sound to swinging 1940's Jump blues. They're widely available in record stores, or call 1-800-35-RHINO in the USA.